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Ben Stokes troubles Aussies like Laxman did: Justin Langer

DH caught up with former Australian opener and head coach Justin Langer, who arrived in the city for a day as brand ambassador of NiviCap before leaving back home for the upcoming commentary commitments for the Ashes. Here are the excerpts of the brief conversation below.



Justin Langer feels Rishabh Pant is at his lethal best when he is joking around on the pitch. Credit: Special arrangement

Cricket fans, especially the purists, are gearing up for a lot of high-quality cricket late in the year with the India-South Africa Test series underway, while the Ashes is just hours away.

While Team India are facing the music for their catastrophic batting display against the World Champions, the likes of Ben Stokes, Joe Root and Steve Smith are ruling the headlines in other parts of the world.

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We always hear how big Ashes is, it's all evident with how both Australian and English media are at loggerheads in the build-up. What can we expect from Australia this time? How do you intend to welcome the English this time, especially at your home ground, the WACA?

I'm looking forward to the Ashes. I'm commentating on Friday morning for Channel 7 and I can't wait. It has been so much noise, there's been so much opinion and speculation on what's going to happen to Joe Root under pressure and what's going to happen to Ben Stokes and Pat Cummins.

Well, it all comes down to the beauty of the game come Friday morning and for the next few days after is the contest between the bat and the ball. So there's great expectation. Ashes series are huge in Australia and we've been all watching.

I very well know how excited fans are here (India) too. Just in for a day here and I've heard it five times today. 'I used wake up at 5:30 in the morning and watch the cricket and see you and (Matthew) Hayden and (Adam) Gilchrist and (Glenn) McGrath and Warne.' We were the same when growing up, watching the Ashes. So there's huge rivalry there.

Is there a prediction from the Ashes series if I asked you to predict the final result?

Prediction? No, no no... I'm not a predictor. Ask Glen McGrath (he laughs). We're ringing Glen McGrath right now and he will give you a prediction. I've been playing, I've been watching cricket way too long, then playing and now coaching. With cricket, who knows, because already there are injuries, there could be form, who knows what's going to happen? And that's the beauty of the particularly Test cricket. It's like a big game of Chess, that's why I love Test cricket.

A lot of focus is on Ben Stokes and Joe Root because of their form and the way they have been winning matches. And then, of course, Ben Stokes is a different beast when he faces Australia?

Ben Stokes is like Laxman against Australia. Every time we played Laxman, he scored tons of runs and took matches away from us. Ben Stokes is the same. Every time he plays us, he finds his mojo, doesn't he? He is a great warrior and such a great leader. He's selflessness means his body wears out and he's got to manage himself. Well, as to do all that for a long five-match test series, both teams have to manage themselves.

And what are your thoughts on Steve Smith coming back in the captaincy role? It's been a while since we saw the best of Smith. Will he ever return to his best again, especially when he is 36?

Yeah, well, I read his numbers. When he is the captain, he averages 69. When he's just playing as a batter, he averages 55. He thrives on leadership, so hit out between him and Stokes is going to be massive. For his form, Smith has been playing domestically leading up (to Ashes). He has played two to three Shield Games (Australia's domestic red-ball cricket). He's blooming beautifully and like all the great players you never write them off. I think he will have a big part to play in this series.

You must have seen the India-South Africa match in Kolkata. The match just got over in three days and we were not expecting that outcome. It was a shambolic show by Indian batters in the second innings. Did you see that coming?

No, of course. But a lot of Test matches are getting over quickly these days. Certainly, the bull spun a lot, very hard playing on spinning conditions in India for anybody, so both teams are a very low-scoring game. India, I suspect, knowing how great a team and how much talent they have, they're going to fight back for the second test.

You have worked up close with Gautam Gambhir. What are your thoughts on how would have approached the match knowing that the pitch is deteriorating fast?

Gautam is a good friend of mine. He's a very strong leader, I have great respect for him, and I mentioned before that India also has no excuses because they arrived four days before from Australia, playing white-ball cricket, and then they're playing a Test match. I understand the international cricket schedule is incredibly busy. That's why I suspect they'll come back very strongly for that second Test match.

Do you think this South African team, especially after winning the WTC, is going to be a different beast and not easy to tame?

I have worked with many of the South Africans in Lucknow this year. They're very fit and very strong and technically very good players. They're hungry and they want to do well, and they've gotten well led by their new coach (Shukri Conrad) and my gosh, they're their really stepping up. Being the current world champions, I have great respect for them.

There's a possibility that Rishabh Pant will take over captaincy duties for the next Test match in Guwahati. How do you look at the possibility of him leading a red-ball side?

I just love Rishabh Pant. I love when he's smiling, laughing and entertaining. Because when he's doing that, he's at his best. My gosh everyone scared of him, such a talented player. I mean, any bowle, no one likes bowling because he's so aggressive. If he captains, it'll be a great honour.